footprint to new geographies, the company acquired a 31 per cent stake in US-based Rising Beverages LLC, which manufactured and marketed a ‘range of vitamin and flavour-enhanced water … under the “Activate” brand’. The company also launched Eight O’Clock Coffee in Europe for the first time and Tata Tea in Germany.

At the 2011 AGM, Ratan announced that TGBL would ‘consider entering the nourishing food segment as part of its plan to become an overall health and wellness company’, an aspect that he was reiterating over the years as part of his vision. It did not end there; he had a larger plan. He said that it may not be long before the company entered the ‘nourishing foods and nourishments of all sorts’, moving a step ahead of the announcement that he had made during the previous AGM.

Ratan said that TGBL was going through a transformation with its goal to be a ‘truly a global beverages and food company’. He traced the company’s evolution and said that it had exited the plantation business and focused on branded tea products in favour of its employees. The vision now was to be the ‘creator and marketer of beverages and foods: ready to drink teas, ready to drink beverages or focus on providing health and wellness rather than mere sweetness and in taste’.

In underlining this goal, Ratan once again revealed the Tata way of doing business, abjuring paths that would be detrimental to people’s health, irrespective of the money that may be at stake.

In 2012, TGBL signed a 50:50 JV agreement with the US-based Starbucks Corporation to bring the famous coffee shop chain to India. Tata would ‘own and operate the cafes’ which were to be ‘branded as Starbucks Coffee “A Tata Alliance”’. In a separate agreement between Tata Coffee and Starbucks Coffee, the former would ‘roast coffee to supply Tata Starbucks’ and to ‘export to Starbucks Coffee globally’.

During the same year, the company took further steps to establish itself as a global wellness company. It ‘launched Tata Water Plus, India’s first nutrient water’. Keeping up with current technology, Tetley entered into an agreement with TASSIMO, ‘Canada’s leading on-demand beverages brand’, to ‘produce, market and sell [Tetley Tea] T-discs exclusively’ for the latter. Eight O’Clock coffee also signed a multi-year agreement with Green Mountain Coffee Roasters to make Good Earth Tea, Tetley Tea and Eight O’Clock Coffee available in convenient packs for ‘single-cup brewing systems’.